



SWMS01

Safe Work Method Statement

Risk of a person falling more than two metres (note: three metres in some jurisdictions)

Document number	EC-SWMS01	Revision	1.0
Prepared by	Ecology Consulting — WHS / Field team	Document release date	
Approved by	Tony Webster — Managing Director / WHS Officer	Next review	

Note: Work must be performed in accordance with this Safe Work Method Statement (SWMS). This SWMS must be kept and available for inspection until the work is completed. If revised, every version must be kept. If a notifiable incident occurs in relation to the work in this SWMS, the SWMS must be kept for at least two years from the date of the notifiable incident. This SWMS is accessed and acknowledged through the Ecology Consulting digital WHS platform; field forms are submitted from site and reviewed centrally by the administration team.

Scope & limitations: Works are limited to ecological survey and observation activities. Ecology Consulting personnel do not erect, alter or dismantle scaffolding, elevating work platforms or fall-protection systems, and do not undertake rope access or industrial abseiling. Fall-arrest systems are used only where an engineer-rated anchorage has been provided and verified by the Principal Contractor and the operator holds current Working at Heights competency. Where a fall risk cannot be eliminated or adequately controlled, the survey is undertaken from ground level or does not proceed.

Project & PCBU details

Person conducting a business or undertaking (PCBU)	Ecology Consulting Pty Ltd · ABN 68 647 633 163	Contact number	0472 569 988 (office / Check-in)
EC offices	34 Atchison St, Wollongong NSW 2500 · 42 Goulburn St, Crookwell NSW 2583 · 473 Townsend St, Albury NSW 2640		
Client / Principal Contractor			
Work activity	Ecological survey and observation near culverts, bridges, embankments, batters, cliff lines, creek banks, retaining structures and other elevated terrain or fall edges.		
Workplace location			

Field work duration

Legislation, codes of practice & standards

Acts & Regulations	Work Health and Safety Act 2011 (NSW) and the Work Health and Safety Regulation (NSW); Work Health and Safety Act 2011 (Cth) and WHS Regulations 2011 (Cth) where work is on Commonwealth land or for a Commonwealth entity (Comcare jurisdiction); Work Health and Safety Act 2011 (ACT) and WHS Regulation 2011 (ACT) for works in the ACT.
Codes of Practice	Safe Work Australia model Codes as adopted in NSW and the ACT: <i>How to manage work health and safety risks; Work health and safety consultation, cooperation and coordination; Construction work; First aid in the workplace; Managing the work environment and facilities; Preparation of safe work method statements for construction work. Managing the risk of falls at workplaces.</i>
Standards & guidance	AS/NZS 1891 Industrial fall-arrest systems and devices; AS/NZS 1800 and AS/NZS 1801 Occupational protective helmets; AS/NZS 2210 Occupational protective footwear; AS/NZS 4602 High visibility safety garments.
EC WHS documentation	EC Work Health and Safety Management System and WHS Handbook; EC Risk Management Processes (EC-RMP-FRM-001); EC Hazard Register and Trigger Action Response List (TARL); Pre-Mobilisation Checklist; Pre-Travel Vehicle Safety Checklist; Journey Management Plan; Daily Toolbox Talk; site-specific Emergency Response Plan (ERP); JSA — General Field Surveys; JSA — Remote and Isolated Work; SOP — Journey Management; SOP — Terrestrial Fauna; SOP — Fieldwork Biosecurity.

Mandatory personal protective equipment & field equipment

Confirmed present and serviceable on the Pre-Mobilisation Checklist and verified by the Field Lead at the Daily Toolbox Talk. Faulty items are tagged out and removed from service.

Hard Hat	Safety Glasses	Gloves	Hearing Protection	Hi-Vis Clothing	Sun Safe PPE	Wide Brim Hat	Capped Boots
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Fire Extinguisher	Remote First Aid Kit	Snake Bite Kit	In Reach / Sat Phone	Two-Way Radio	Torch / Headlamp	GPS	Drinking Water
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Fall-Arrest Harness & Lanyard	Rated Anchorage (PC provided)	Non-Slip Footwear	Backpack (hands free)	Extendable Survey Pole	Binoculars / Camera	Head Torch	Two-Person Team
☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐

Hierarchy of controls

Eliminate	Plan surveys to avoid working at height or near fall edges — assess from safe ground, use binoculars, cameras, extendable poles, drones or existing data rather than approaching the edge.
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Substitute	Use safer survey methods — conduct observations from stable ground or from the base of a structure rather than accessing steep, elevated or unstable areas.
Isolate	Establish exclusion zones around edges, cliffs, culverts, steep batters and unstable ground; maintain safe setback distances and mark no-go zones.
Engineer	Use physical controls where available — existing railings, edge protection, defined tracks, stable platforms and secured access points — rather than natural or unstable terrain.
Administrative	SWMS, site-specific risk assessment, route planning, buddy system, weather checks, clearly defined no-go zones, and enforced stop-work triggers for wet, loose or unstable conditions.
PPE	Last line of defence — sturdy boots with grip, helmets where an overhead or edge risk exists, and harness systems only where approved, anchored and necessary.

Hazards & controls

Complete for each survey location. Reassess whenever site conditions, weather or the survey position change.

What are the hazards & risks	What are the control measures	Select relevant controls (completed onsite by Field Lead)
Planning, preparation and travelling to site		
Inadequate planning leading to uncontrolled risk; unfit or untrained personnel	Attend the pre-field meeting with the Project Lead and Project Manager to review scope, methodology and expected hazards; confirm site access, keys, codes, inductions and property constraints; and confirm all staff are trained, competent and fit for work. Medical concerns are disclosed privately to the Field Lead. Review this SWMS, the relevant JSA and SOP, the Field Plan and the site-specific ERP. Verify training currency — workers are not mobilised with expired mandatory training.	☐ Pre-field meeting ☐ SWMS / JSA / SOP reviewed ☐ ERP reviewed ☐ Training verified ☐ Medical disclosures
Vehicle failure, missing safety equipment or fatigue during travel	Complete the Pre-Travel Vehicle Safety Checklist — first aid kit, extinguisher, spare tyre, torch, water and PPE present; vehicle free from leaks, faults or damage; electrical issues visually inspected only and tagged out if unsafe. Complete the Journey Management Plan. Minimum 10-hour rest between shifts before driving; personal fatigue self-assessment before departure; rest breaks every two hours; carry water, snacks and electrolytes; second driver for long or remote trips where practicable. Zero blood alcohol concentration applies to all work driving.	☐ Vehicle checklist done ☐ JMP completed ☐ 10-hr rest confirmed ☐ Fatigue self-assessment
Travelling into fire, flood, storm, smoke or hazardous road conditions	Complete the Pre-Travel Environmental and Hazard Check using BOM weather warnings, Hazards Near Me, RFS fire danger ratings, Air Quality Index, lightning trackers, Live Traffic NSW and telecommunications coverage maps. Do not travel where there are emergency warning fire events, hazardous air quality, active storm warnings or flooded roads. Never drive through floodwater under any circumstance. If conditions change, stop, reassess and notify the Communication Officer.	☐ BOM / Hazards Near Me ☐ RFS rating checked ☐ AQI checked ☐ Live Traffic NSW ☐ Coverage checked
Hazards not identified, assessed or communicated before work commences	All team members participate in a pre-commencement Daily Toolbox Talk led on site by the Field Lead and documented on the EC WHS form — site-specific hazards identified; collaborative risk assessment using the EC risk matrix (rating one to six) with agreed controls and a revised residual rating; PPE and equipment readiness confirmed; ERP reviewed and Emergency Meeting Point identified; communication and check-in requirements confirmed; health or access needs disclosed privately; and worker sign-on confirming understanding and fitness for work. Hazards already in the EC Hazard Register are managed under the TARL. No worker commences without sign-on.	☐ Toolbox talk held ☐ Risk assessment rated ☐ Emergency Meeting Point ☐ All workers signed on
Loss of contact with the field team; delayed emergency response	Mandatory check-ins with the Communication Officer (0472 569 988) before departing base, on arrival at site or accommodation, before leaving site, and on return to base. Every check-in must be acknowledged. A missed or unacknowledged check-in triggers escalation through the Communication Officer, Project Lead or Project Manager, and the WHS Officer, and is grounds for activating the ERP. Carry redundant communications — mobile phone, UHF radio and In Reach or satellite communicator, with a PLB where remoteness warrants. Roles are assigned at the toolbox talk: Field Lead, Communication Officer and workers.	☐ Check-in schedule agreed ☐ Comms tested ☐ Roles assigned ☐ Escalation briefed
Arrival and vehicle positioning near elevated terrain		

What are the hazards & risks	What are the control measures	Select relevant controls (completed onsite by Field Lead)
Vehicle roll-back or rollover near steep edges; vehicle instability leading to fall exposure; personnel exiting vehicles near drop-offs	Park on firm, level ground well away from embankments, culvert headwalls and edges, with the handbrake applied and wheels turned away from the fall. Maintain a safe setback distance from slopes, culverts and drop-offs. Position the vehicle so that entry and exit is onto flat, stable ground. Apply hazard awareness when opening doors near slopes; exit on the uphill side where practicable.	☐ Firm level parking ☐ Setback maintained ☐ Safe entry / exit side
Walking to and accessing survey locations		
Slips, trips and falls leading to a fall from height; unstable ground or hidden hazards causing loss of footing	Plan safe access routes that avoid edges wherever possible and brief them to the team before setting out. Maintain a safe distance from drop-offs at all times. Wear appropriate footwear with good tread. Maintain situational awareness and avoid distractions — do not walk while reading data sheets, phones or GPS units. Move slowly and deliberately in dense vegetation and visually confirm the ground ahead before each step.	☐ Route planned & briefed ☐ Distance from edges ☐ Footwear checked ☐ No walking while recording
Restricted movement or loss of balance while transporting equipment across uneven or elevated terrain	Use backpacks to keep hands free. Limit load weight and size; split loads and make multiple trips rather than overloading. Maintain a clear line of sight when moving. Avoid carrying equipment near edges — stage equipment away from the fall zone and retrieve it as required.	☐ Backpacks used ☐ Load limited ☐ Line of sight clear
Survey work on or near steep ground, culverts and structures		
Slips or trips resulting in a fall down a slope or over an edge; loss of footing on unstable or loose ground	Avoid working on steep slopes where possible — eliminate the risk in preference to controlling it. Undertake work from the bottom of the slope or from stable ground where practicable. Test ground stability before committing weight. Maintain three points of contact when moving on steep ground. Do not carry heavy loads that affect balance.	☐ Slope avoided where possible ☐ Ground tested ☐ Three points of contact
Falling from height due to overreaching or leaning; collapse of ground near culvert or structure edges; loss of balance working near drop-offs	Reassess the survey position to undertake the inspection from ground level wherever possible. Do not lean over edges or enter unsafe areas. Assess edge stability — including undercutting, cracking and saturation — prior to approaching. Maintain a minimum safe distance from culvert or structure edges. Work in pairs wherever a fall risk is present. Use extendable equipment rather than reaching.	☐ Ground-level alternative ☐ No leaning over edges ☐ Edge stability assessed ☐ Working in pairs
Falling from height into water; slippery and unstable creek banks and channel edges	Avoid unstable or eroded banks entirely. Maintain a safe working distance from the water edge. Work in pairs with continuous visual contact. Identify safe access and exit points before starting work. Where an immersion risk exists, apply the controls in SWMS18 including a buoyancy aid and floating rescue rope.	☐ Eroded banks avoided ☐ Visual contact kept ☐ Access / exit identified ☐ SWMS18 applied
Environmental conditions and fatigue		
Slippery surfaces and reduced visibility during or after rainfall, increasing misjudgement of edges	Postpone work in unsafe weather conditions. Assess ground and edge stability before proceeding — saturated ground fails without warning. Allow additional time and caution when moving. Cease work if conditions become unsafe and withdraw to stable ground.	☐ Weather assessed ☐ Ground reassessed ☐ Postponed if unsafe
Inability to identify drop-offs or edges in low light; missteps leading to a fall from height	Ensure adequate lighting — carry a head torch with spare batteries. Do not work near fall hazards in poor visibility. Schedule work during adequate daylight where possible. Where night survey is required, walk and assess the route in daylight beforehand.	☐ Lighting adequate ☐ Daylight scheduling ☐ Daylight recce (night work)

What are the hazards & risks	What are the control measures	Select relevant controls (completed onsite by Field Lead)
Reduced focus and delayed reactions during prolonged fieldwork near fall hazards	Schedule regular breaks away from the fall zone. Monitor fatigue levels within the team and buddy-check for fatigue indicators. Rotate tasks where possible. Cease work if fatigue impacts safety and notify the Communication Officer.	☐ Breaks scheduled ☐ Fatigue monitored ☐ Tasks rotated

Stop-work triggers — stop work immediately, move to a safe location, notify the Field Lead and Principal Contractor, and do not recommence until the risk is controlled and communicated			
Ground or edge found to be unstable	Wet, loose or slippery surface conditions	Visibility reduced by rain, fog, smoke or low light	Fall-arrest anchorage unavailable or unverified
High wind affecting balance	Fatigue affecting safe movement	Loss of communication or visual contact	Any situation where a worker feels unsafe

Emergency response

Read with the site-specific Emergency Response Plan. The Field Lead is the Chief Warden. Any worker may activate the ERP.

1 · Activate & make safe	Stop work and ensure the area is safe for responders. Do not move an injured person unless there is immediate danger. Prepare a safe route for stretcher or rescue equipment and use ropes or harnesses only where the terrain requires controlled movement and personnel are trained to do so. The Field Lead assesses the situation, initiates the response, directs evacuation to the Emergency Meeting Point, accounts for all personnel using the Daily Toolbox Talk sign-on sheet, and coordinates communication with the office.
2 · Call for help	Call 000 or 112, or activate the In Reach or PLB where there is no coverage. Provide GPS coordinates and the nearest cross roads, the nature of the emergency and safe access routes. Assign one person to guide responders in.
3 · First aid	A trained first aider assesses the casualty, but only where it is safe to do so. Control bleeding, immobilise suspected fractures and monitor breathing. If unconscious but breathing, place in the recovery position; if not breathing, commence CPR. Record all treatment on the First Aid Treatment Log.
4 · Post-incident	Report to the WHS Officer and complete an Incident Report Form within the required timeframe, submitted through the digital WHS platform. The WHS Officer updates the Incident Register and notifies the regulator of any notifiable incident. Attend debrief; review and update this SWMS and the ERP; restock emergency equipment used. Psychosocial support is provided where workers were exposed to distressing events.

Emergency services	000 or 112	State Emergency Service (SES)	13 25 00
EC office / Check-in Officer	0472 569 988	Managing Director / WHS Officer	Tony Webster · 0448 439 334
Poisons Information Hotline	13 11 26	Wildlife rescue	1300 094 737
Employee Assistance Program	1300 172 327 — free and confidential	Nearest hospital & muster point	Identified per site in the ERP; confirmed at the toolbox talk

Training & competency requirements

Required for this activity	Working at Heights training is required for any worker using a fall-arrest system or working where a fall-arrest system is the control. Only trained personnel fit, inspect and use harnesses and lanyards, which are inspected before every use and tagged out if damaged.
Baseline — all field personnel	White Card (General Construction Induction); current driver's licence of appropriate class; CPR certification (annual renewal); Provide First Aid (HLTAID011), and Remote First Aid (HLTAID013) for remote or isolated work; General Fauna Handling Training.
Verification	All training must be current, recorded and verifiable prior to mobilisation. Records are maintained by the Administration Officer and retained for a minimum of five years, with expiry notifications issued in advance; workers are not mobilised with expired mandatory training. Competency is verified annually and observed on site by Principal or Senior Ecologists, Project Managers and the WHS Officer. Subcontractor training evidence is collected and retained for audit.

Daily SWMS acknowledgement & sign-on register

All personnel must read, understand and sign this SWMS before commencing work, confirming they are fit for duty, competent and able to perform assigned tasks safely. Completed with the Daily Toolbox Talk and submitted through the digital WHS platform.

#	Name	Role	Signature	Date
1				
2				
3				
4				
5				
6				

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